

HTPC software you can use

Bored of the Windows Media Centre, here are 10 alternatives to it <http://goo.gl/bHpXJ>

Bypassing WMP gates

Download the K-Lite codec from this site to play every file format that you throw at Media Player Classic: <http://goo.gl/g6Ts>

Probable HTPC recommendations based on usage scenarios

Usage Scenario	Scenario 1: Multimedia & Office (Assuming you already have an HDTV and speaker system in place)		Scenario 2: Regular Computer (I want all the benefits of a regular computer, but at the same time, cost factor is very important. I am on a budget of around ₹20,000. My expectations from the system are watching Blu-ray HD content flawlessly, do a bit of surfing, online video streaming. I also have a lot of video files that i would like to encode to various formats.)		Scenario 3: Extreme Budget (I am an extreme budget buyer and my primary aim is to be able to watch Blu-ray HD content. I will not be indulging in a lot of productivity on this system as i have my fully specced desktop for that. But i would like to surf once in a while on this system)	
	Components	Price (₹)	Components	Price (₹)	Components	Price (₹)
Processor	Intel Core i5 2500	10,200	Intel Core i3 2100	5,500	AMD E350	onboard
Motherboard	ZOTAC Z68ITX AE	9,999	ZOTAC H67 Mini ITX	6,000	ECS HDC I2	5,500
Cabinet	Cooler Master Elite 100	3,200	iBall Baby 306	1,600	iBall Baby 306	1,600
Cost so far		23,399		13,100		7,100
Common Components						
RAM	4 GB DDR3 Corsair Vengeance RAM (₹2,500)					
HDD	Seagate Barracuda LP 2 TB (₹4,250)					
Cooler	Stock cooler / heat sinks for the processor (free)					
Wireless Keyboard	Amkette Cruiser Wireless Keyboard and Mouse (₹1,140)					
Total Cost		₹31,289		₹20,990		₹14,990

decided to use the new Zacate board featuring the AMD E350 processor which is clocked at 1.6GHz. It houses the lower end HD 6310 integrated graphics. This is a budget HTPC which will give you a decent performance for absolute basic tasks such as working on documents, Excel, etc. and watching Blu-ray HD content. Considering the low spec processor, you can forget about using heavy applications such as Photoshop.

Note that this isn't a comparison, but the scores in the table are an indication of the kind of performance you can expect. The Sandy Bridge rig for instance was great for performing tasks such as transcoding and CPU-intensive work. The AMD E350 rig, on the other hand, is great for watching HD content, but transcoding and other CPU-intensive tasks will be slow. Also note that the CPU utilisation while watching an HD movie on the Sandy Bridge rig was hovering around 6 - 7 per cent, whereas on the AMD E350 board it was around the 50 per cent mark.

You should ideally select components which lie within these extremes based on your budget. We've also given processor and motherboard recommendations based on market prices in the table above.

If you just want a barebones download

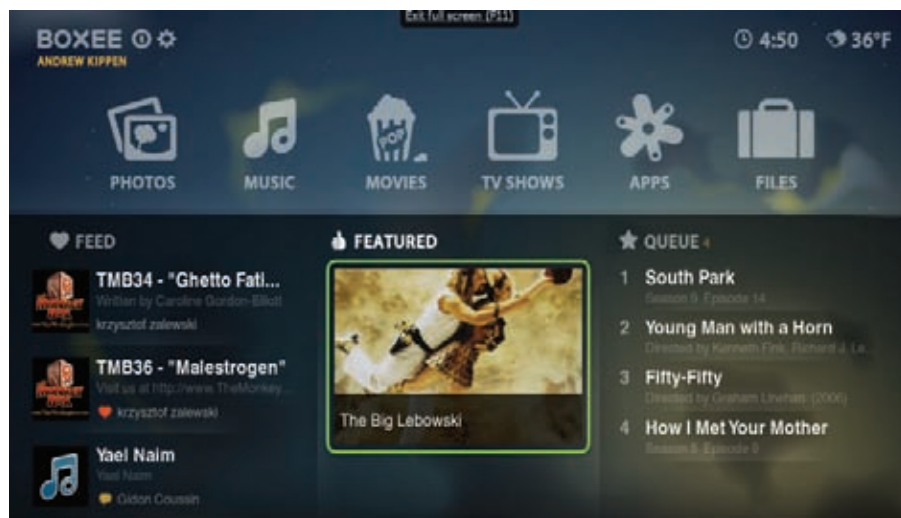
rig then you can go for an older generation Intel Atom based mini ITX board. You can just connect your LAN cable to the system and use this system to download torrents. As it is a low power system, you can keep it on for weeks if you so want.

Good to know...

Select a processor based on applications you'll use

A processor comes with many specifications such as clock frequency, number of cores and integrated graphics. You'll need

to select an appropriate processor based on your usage scenario. For instance, if you perform transcoding operations frequently, then it's great if you could get a processor with a higher number of cores – preferably with an integrated GPU, rather than just a higher clock frequency (for example, Intel's Core i3, i5, i7 processors). Higher number of cores will ensure that the task is completed quickly and the integrated GPU eliminates the need for a discrete graphics card, thus keeping the power considerably lower.



A screenshot of the user interface in the Boxee media player hub